Bharat Jodo: Restoring Kashmiriyat, Jamhooriyat and Insaniyat

Mehbooba Mufti and Iltija Mufti

I must be honest. When I first received an invitation to walk with RG (Rahul Gandhi) for the Bharat Jodo Yatra in Kashmir, I had my fair share of nagging doubts. Since my release from two years of illegal detention, there has been many a time when I've been placed under house arrest only because our party, the PDP, wanted to take out peaceful marches. If this was the treatment meted out to local regional parties, I wondered how the local administration—headed by a BJP man—could ever allow their main opponent to walk through the roads of a state that has been converted into an open-air prison since 2019. My fears weren't misplaced.

As RG crossed the Jawahar Tunnel to enter the Valley, he was welcomed by thousands of not only enthusiastic Congress workers but also common people. For reasons best known to them, the local security personnel around him vanished without a trace. RG was left to his own devices and the team hurriedly left the venue, understandably owing to security reasons.

I was meant to join his Yatra the very next day in south Kashmir on 28 January. On that freezing night, as I mentioned to my mother about joining RG, I was in for a surprise. She insisted on walking with him. As RG traversed thousands of kilometres through the country, my mother scrolled through his videos every day. The sight of a young man vilified and berated, yet being showered with such deep affection must have struck a chord somewhere with her. I was pleasantly shocked. Ever since my father passed away in 2016, she refused to leave the four walls of our house. RG had achieved the impossible. Seeing him so vulnerable seemed to have evoked a motherly instinct. But I was also concerned. We were in the middle of